

INTELLIGENCE

Playing I Spy With That Alleged New Openness at the CIA

Some habits are hard to break

By George Lardner Jr.
Washington Post Staff Writer

When CIA Director Robert M. Gates publicly promised "a greater openness and sense of public responsibility" at the intelligence agency a few weeks ago, he was acting on the recommendations of a special task force that had studied ways to make the agency more visible, credible and responsive to the outside world.

But when the 15-page "Task Force Report on Greater CIA Openness" was submitted to Gates Dec. 20, it was stamped "Secret," a classification formally reserved for information "the unauthorized disclosure of which reasonably could be expected to cause serious damage to the national security."

CIA officials refused to disclose any of the report, even in the wake of Gates's Feb. 21 speech. "An internal document," an agency spokesman told a reporter that day. "We determined [it] must be withheld in its entirety," the agency informed the American Civil Liberties Union's Center for National Security Studies about two weeks later in response to a request under the Freedom of Information Act.

Now, after public scolding at a House hearing, Gates has approved declassification of almost the entire report as well as his five-page

decision directive, dated Jan. 6, and sent them to one of the scolders, Democratic Rep. Lee H. Hamilton of Indiana, former chairman of the House intelligence committee.

Much of the task force's report simply mirrors, albeit with more detail, what Gates announced publicly: initiatives to declassify historical records, greater accessibility to the press on the part of agency officials, expanded contacts with public audiences and colleges and universities. It is difficult to discern anything that would do "serious damage to the national security."

There are, however, some items that might be considered embarrassing. The report shows that despite agreement within the agency and outside it on the need for more openness, the CIA's public affairs office, expected to be a mainstay of the new look, is being forced to cut its budget by a third.

"We recognize that a program of increased openness will require commitment of additional resources, not only for PAO [the public affairs office] but for other parts of the agency," the report said.

The task force, headed by then-CIA public affairs director Joseph DeTrani, also touted what it saw as the accomplishments of the agency's existing media program.



BY TIM CLARK FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

"PAO now has relationships with reporters from every major wire service, newspaper, news weekly and television network in the nation," the report said. "This has helped us turn some 'intelligence failure' stories into 'intelligence success' stories, and it has contributed to the accuracy of countless others."

"In many instances," the report continued, "we have persuaded reporters to postpone, change, hold or even scrap stories that could have adversely affected national security interests or jeopardized sources and methods."

Gates rejected some of the task force recommendations, including a proposal that the public affairs office give unclassified background briefings to reporters "when there is a major international event" such as the Persian Gulf War.

The CIA director said he was "inclined to support" a proposal to declassify records on specific events, "particularly those which are repeatedly the subject of false allegations, such as the 1948 Italian elections, 1953 Iranian coup, 1954 Guatemalan coup, 1958 Indonesian

coup and the Cuban Missile Crisis in 1962."

The CIA had been adamant about keeping the report under wraps as recently as March 18, when the new PAO director, Gary Foster, was questioned about it by House Government Operations Committee Chairman John Conyers Jr. of Michigan at a hearing on government secrecy.

Foster said people whose names are classified were mentioned in the report. He said some portions might not be classified, "but taken out of context, they wouldn't mean much to anybody." As it turned out, only the names were excised from the report and decision directive that Gates sent Hamilton April 13.

"It's a step in the right direction for the agency and I applaud that," Hamilton says. But Leslie Harris, Washington ACLU legislative director, calls it "disappointing."

"It reads like an internal discussion of how we can get people to like us," Harris says. "It doesn't call for a serious look at what secrecy is really necessary now that the Cold War is over."

The names of task force members, including DeTrani, were deleted. And so were the names of journalists, business leaders, academics and others who, the report said, "shared their views on CIA openness with the task force." That list presumably includes Washington Post executive editor Leonard Downie Jr. and other Post editors whom DeTrani consulted last fall on a visit to the newspaper.

CIA spokesman Peter Earnest says the names of those the CIA consulted were blacked out under FOIA provisions permitting secrecy for "deliberative" materials and for the agency's "sources and methods."

"I'm not a CIA 'source,'" Downie says. "They visited us quite openly. We wanted to tell them how they could tell us more about what they do. It sounded as if they were interested in being more open and in finding ways of making the CIA more accessible to us so we could cover them better."

By Edward Walsh
Washington Post Staff Writer

T. PAUL. Minn. — Overcoming fears

HEALTH CARE

ance coverage will be phased in beginning with children and their parents this fall and will be

Too many secrets

Tucson Citizen
JULY 93

Time to declassify the history of the Cold War

Nobody knows how many secrets this nation has.

Classified documents are stored in more than 80,000 government depositories. The National Archives alone has an estimated 325 million pages of classified documents. "It's a huge mountain," said Steven Garfinkel, director of the Information Security Oversight Office, "perhaps billions."

The big problem is that the mountain of secrets grows daily. A 1981 directive from the Reagan administration strengthened the national security laws that require things to be stamped "Top Secret," "Secret," "Confidential," or one of the many code words for documents that are more secret than "Top Secret."

Last year, the Pentagon, the CIA, the State Department and the White House combined to contribute another six million classified documents.

Many of the secrets are old, dating as far back as the World War I era.

Many of the secrets aren't worth keeping. They deal with a Cold War world that has vanished.

But the process of declassification is slow and tedious.

President Clinton wants to speed it up before the National Archives and the other depositories drown in a sea of paperwork they can neither use nor destroy. He ordered that Cold War rules on secrecy be reviewed with an eye toward whittling away at the paper mountain.

He also wants to restrict the growth of

newly classified material. His order sets up a task force to develop new rules for document secrecy that answer three questions:

What really needs to be kept secret?

How can information be declassified speedily?

How can excessive secrecy be avoided?

We should wish the president good luck in his endeavor, recognizing that others have tried and failed before him to reduce the secret archives and slow down the growth of secrets.

The New York Times pointed out in a story recently that Presidents Carter and Nixon, who issued similar orders, met resistance from the intelligence services.

Those services were successful in preserving the confidentiality of their missions — and in covering up their mistakes.

The current heads of those services are said to be amenable to giving up some secrets. The Cold War is over, after all.

Scholars and historians will benefit greatly from declassification. It's not just the mists of time that shroud the Cold War from view, it's the paper curtain of classified documents.

America's reputation as an open society suffers in comparison to formerly closed societies like the Soviet Union that are now releasing a wealth of historical information.

It's time this old democracy joined those new democracies in an honest review of our recent past. It's time to put the past four decades into the history books.